Predicting Coronary Heart Disease from the 2015 BRFSS Survey

Tommaso Sommaruga, Paolo Ferrari, Francesco Foglia
CS-433 Machine Learning, Project 1, EPFL, Switzerland

***Abstract*—We predict from the 2015 Behavioral Risk Factor Surveillance System (BRFSS) whether a respondent reports coronary heart disease or a heart attack (MICHD); only 8.8% of the 328,135 training rows are positive, so we optimise the positive-class F1. On the same features as the six course methods, a small neural network (Linear–BatchNorm–ReLU) fits the training data better but does not beat logistic regression on held-out data (F1 0.425 versus 0.429): the limit is the signal in the features, not the model capacity. The gains come from the preprocessing: treating every answer code as a category and keeping the 300 one-hot levels with the highest mutual information beats other encodings by up to 0.08 F1. Our class-weighted logistic regression reaches a 5-fold F1 of 0.427 ± 0.002 and an AIcrowd F1 of 0.439 (accuracy 0.877).**

I. Introduction

Cardiovascular diseases are a leading cause of death. The BRFSS telephone survey of the U.S. Centers for Disease Control and Prevention records health status, chronic conditions and lifestyle of U.S. adults. From the 321 answers of a respondent we predict the label $y \in \{-1, +1\}$ (MICHD). We compare the six methods seen in class with a small neural network, to test whether more capacity helps; since it does not, we focus on the preprocessing. Only NumPy and Matplotlib are used; `run.py` reproduces our best AIcrowd submission.

II. Models and Methods

A. Data and exploratory analysis

The training set has 328,135 rows and the test set 109,379, both with 321 features. 44.8% of the cells are blank in both sets, 147 columns are more than half empty (optional modules, skip patterns) and 6 are constant. Most columns are coded categories: on day-count questions 88 means "none" and 77/99 mean "don't know"/"refused", so the numeric value is meaningless. The positive rate grows from 0.5% at age 18–24 to 22.2% at 80+, and is 11.2% for men versus 7.1% for women. On 87 columns the missing rate differs between the classes by more than 5 points, so a blank is itself informative. Four items on cardiac and stroke rehabilitation and aspirin use (`HAREHAB1`, `STREHAB1`, `CVDASPRN`, `ASPUNSAF`) concern only people with a cardiac history; we treat them as label leaks.

B. Preprocessing

The pipeline of `src/preprocessing.py` is fitted on training rows only, then frozen and applied to validation and test rows.

1) *Column removal.* We drop 40 columns that describe the interview rather than the person (state, dates, sequence number, phone checks, sampling weights), the 4 leak columns, and columns that are empty or constant.
2) *Level encoding.* Each remaining column becomes indicator (one-hot) levels. A value held by at least 1% of the rows gets its own level, so special codes such as 77, 88 and 99 stay separate categories; the rarer values are cut into at most 5 quantile bins (or pooled into one level), and "missing" is a level when at least 1% of the rows are blank.
3) *Selection.* Constant and duplicate indicators are removed (about 1,750 remain) and the 300 with the highest mutual information with the label are kept. They come from 143 raw columns.
4) *Standardisation* with the training mean and standard deviation.

C. Course methods

We compare the six required methods: least squares with gradient descent (GD) and with stochastic gradient descent (SGD, batch size 1), least squares and ridge regression with the normal equations, and logistic and ℓ_2-regularised logistic regression with GD (all in `implementations.py`). We fit them on the preprocessed matrix plus a bias column, with targets $y \in \{0, 1\}$, zero initialisation and the grids of Table I. GD step sizes are fractions of the stability limit, $2/L$ for the squared and $8/L$ for the logistic loss, where $L = 29.7$ is the top eigenvalue of $X^\top X/n$.

D. Neural network

We implemented in NumPy (`neural_net.py`) a multilayer perceptron with two hidden layers of 128 and 64 units, each Linear $\to$ BatchNorm $\to$ ReLU, and a linear output (He initialisation). `train.py` trains it on the same features with binary cross-entropy, positives weighted by $n_-/n_+ = 10.3$, Adam (learning rate $\in \{10^{-3}, 10^{-4}\}$, weight decay $\in \{0, 0.1\}$), batches of 256 and early stopping on the tune-slice loss (patience 5).

Table I
ALL MODELS ON FOLD 0 (SAME FEATURES AND PROTOCOL; SETTING CHOSEN BY F1 ON THE TUNE SLICE).

Method	Setting	F1	PR-AUC
Least squares (normal eq.)	–	0.419	0.386
Ridge regression	$\lambda = 10^{-2}$	0.421	0.385
Least squares, GD	$\gamma = 0.034$	0.420	0.385
Least squares, SGD	$\gamma = 10^{-4}$	0.413	0.371
Logistic regression, GD	$\gamma = 0.13$	0.429	**0.396**
Reg. logistic regression, GD	$\lambda = 10^{-3}$, $\gamma = 0.13$	**0.430**	**0.396**
MLP 128–64, BN, ReLU	lr $= 10^{-3}$, wd $= 0$	0.425	0.385
Weighted logistic, FISTA*	$\lambda = 10^{-5}$	0.427	0.392

Grids: ridge $\lambda \in \{10^{-5}, \dots, 10^{-2}\}$; GD $\gamma \in \{0.017, 0.034, 0.064\}$; SGD $\gamma \in \{10^{-4}, 10^{-3}\}$ ($2 \cdot 10^5$ steps); logistic $\gamma \in \{0.067, 0.13, 0.26\}$; reg. logistic $\lambda \in \{10^{-4}, 10^{-3}, 10^{-2}\}$; GD methods 500 steps. *Submitted.

E. Submitted model

Let $y_i \in \{0, 1\}$ and give each row a weight w_i such that the positive rows together weigh twice the negative ones. We minimise

$$\min_{\theta} \frac{1}{n} \sum_{i=1}^{n} w_i \, \ell\big(y_i, \theta_0 + x_i^\top \theta_{1:}\big) + \lambda \|\theta_{1:}\|_2^2, \qquad (1)$$

with $\ell(y, s) = \log(1 + e^s) - ys$ and $\lambda = 10^{-5}$ (the bias is not penalised), by 300 steps of FISTA (Nesterov-accelerated gradient descent) with step $1/(1.1\,\hat{L}/4 + 2\lambda)$, $\hat{L}$ being the top eigenvalue of the weighted Gram matrix.

F. Decision threshold and validation

For a rare class F1 is not maximised at probability 0.5. Inside every training set we hold out a stratified 15% *tune* slice and choose the score cut t that maximises F1 among 201 quantiles of the tune scores. The generalisation error is estimated by stratified 5-fold cross-validation (seed 42): in each fold, preprocessing and model are fitted on 85% of the four training folds, t on the other 15%, and the held-out fold is scored once. For Table I we use fold 0 (65,627 held-out rows) and also pick each method's hyperparameters on the tune slice. The submission (`run.py`, settings in `config/experiments.json`) repeats the 85/15 procedure on all labelled rows; it gives $t = 1.75$, labels 13.16% of the test rows positive and writes `submissions/weighted_logistic.csv`.

III. RESULTS

Course methods. The six methods span 0.413–0.430 F1 (Table I); the logistic loss beats the squared loss by about 0.01 in F1 and PR-AUC. SGD with batch size 1 is the weakest.

Neural network. The setting chosen on the tune slice reaches F1 0.425 (others 0.424–0.426), no better than logistic regression (0.429). Its tune loss is lowest after only 2 epochs and it fits its training rows better than it generalises (F1 0.445 versus 0.425), while logistic regression shows no gap (0.430 versus 0.429). The linear model is thus not underfitting, and extra capacity only fits noise: the limit is the signal in the features. We submit the weighted logistic regression (used for Table II, best on AIcrowd).

Table II
PREPROCESSING ABLATION WITH THE SUBMITTED MODEL: 5-FOLD MEANS (STANDARD DEVIATION OF F1 BETWEEN 0.001 AND 0.003).

Representation	F1	PR-AUC	ROC-AUC	Cols
One-hot, MI top 300*	**0.427**	**0.388**	**0.861**	300
One-hot, all levels, ℓ_1	0.425	0.385	0.859	1753
One-hot, all levels	0.422	0.382	0.857	1753
Codebook recode	0.422	0.386	0.859	171
Codebook + one-hot	0.422	0.382	0.857	1924
One-hot $\times$ (age $\geq$ 65)	0.422	0.381	0.857	1864
Numeric, median + flags	0.410	0.359	0.851	464
Same, <50% missing cols	0.407	0.355	0.850	215
Numeric + flags on top 40	0.395	0.336	0.841	227
Missing flags only	0.343	0.270	0.807	187

*Submitted representation.

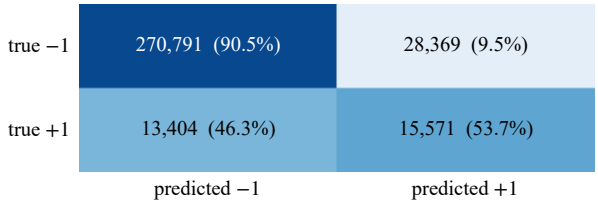


Figure 1. Submitted model, pooled over the five held-out folds (row percentages): precision 0.354, recall 0.537, F1 0.427, accuracy 0.873.

Preprocessing ablation. Table II changes only the representation (code: `src/pipeline_experiments.py`, commit `9c5b69a`). Reading the codes as numbers with median imputation and missing flags loses 0.017 F1 and 0.029 PR-AUC. Missing flags alone lose 0.084 F1: blanks carry signal, but much less than the answers. A hand-made clinical codebook, all 1,753 one-hot levels (with or without an ℓ_1 penalty) or products with an age $\geq$ 65 flag reach at most 0.425: the extra columns repeat what the 300 selected levels carry. On AIcrowd, better preprocessing raised F1 from 0.391 to 0.439, close to the 5-fold estimate.

IV. DISCUSSION

Almost half of the positives (46.3%) are scored like negatives (Fig. 1): this class overlap, not the model, bounds the score. With a tuned threshold the class weight barely matters (in earlier runs, weights from 0.5 to 6 changed F1 by 0.001), but the threshold must match the metric: tuning it for F2 drops F1 to about 0.38.

V. SUMMARY

Baselines, a neural network and preprocessing ablations agree: the bottleneck is the signal in the survey answers, so the gains came from the preprocessing (5-fold F1 0.427 ± 0.002, AIcrowd F1 0.439, accuracy 0.877).